



100+ questions associations should be asking members

Conversational Engagement, one question at a time. Ask. Capture. Act.

Members don't want more content. They want more connection.

When this guide first launched, it struck a chord. “100+ Questions Associations Should Be Asking Members” became one of our most downloaded resources. Because deep down, most of us already know the truth:

Members don't want more content. They want more connection.

Imagine having just one member to support today. No deadlines, no backlog, no competing priorities. It's just you and that member. And your focus is on helping them get as much value as possible from your association.

So...how do you help them?

You probably wouldn't start by blasting them with information or hoping your latest newsletter happens to hit the mark. You'd start with a conversation. You'd ask questions about their goals, their career, why they joined, what they need next, or simply: “How can we help you today?”

That's how humans build understanding. We ask, we listen, and then we act based on what we learn. This is the heart of Conversational Engagement.

Since we first published this ebook, the pace of change in associations has accelerated. Personalized experiences, AI, shifting expectations, member churn...there's more noise than ever. But the most effective path forward still begins the same way it always has:

With a question.

In this updated edition, we've refreshed, expanded, and modernized the questions based on what we're seeing today – from onboarding to renewals, lapsed-member outreach, certifications, career support, and more. Our goal is simple:

To help you spark conversations that reveal what your members actually need—so you can respond with relevance, not guesswork.

Let's get started.

What's [still] missing from today's member engagement?

Before we dive into questions that help start better conversations, it's worth pausing to look at how most member engagement still works today and where the gaps remain.

Broadcasting Is Still the Default

Most associations communicate through broadcasts. We have a lot of important information to share about events, education, advocacy updates, certifications, resources, you name it. And oftentimes, the most practical way to distribute it at scale is through newsletters and broad announcements.

To be clear: broadcasts serve a purpose. They keep members informed. They create awareness. They help ensure critical information gets out the door.

But broadcasts are, by design, one-way. Even when messages are “targeted,” the interaction usually stops at opens and clicks. We can see what someone engaged with, but not why. We know they clicked, but not whether the content solved a problem, answered a question, or created confusion.

In most cases, members aren't being invited to respond. And even if they are, few teams have the systems, workflows, or capacity to manage thousands of one-off replies in a meaningful way. So engagement becomes something we send, not learn from.

Over the last few years, associations have invested in better tools, better data, and more personalized messaging. That progress matters. And yet, a critical piece is still missing – a scalable way to listen.

True engagement is about understanding what members actually need in the moment and being able to respond accordingly. That requires two-way communication. It requires asking questions, capturing responses, and acting on what members tell you. Without that feedback loop, we're left guessing. We infer intent from behavior. We assume relevance based on role or segment. And we hope our content lands at the right time.

Two-way communications

This is where Conversational Engagement comes in.

Conversational Engagement doesn't replace broadcasts—it complements them. It is based on the premise that what your members have to tell you is just as important as what you have to tell your members. There are many ways to get your members to talk to you. The simplest way?

Ask them a question. Conversational Engagement is built around a simple framework: Ask → Capture → Act.

ASK

What do you value?
What do you need? What
are your pain points?

CAPTURE

Insights into individual
wants, needs and
interests.

ACT

To deliver immediate and
long term value to the
member.

Go back to the example of how you would best help a member: you ask a question, you capture an answer, you act to help them get what they need. This isn't always a linear or one-time process. Sometimes your action is simply to ask a follow-up question to learn more.

Other times, it might mean pointing someone to a course, connecting them with a resource, or helping them take the next step that moves them forward.

The key is ongoing, two-way communication where you're continually learning more about your members, and responding in ways that are relevant, timely, and helpful.

When that happens, engagement stops being about messages sent and starts becoming about value delivered and relationships strengthened.

Ask questions

What's the easiest way to engage people, whether it's via email, SMS or even on your website? Ask them a question.

Think about how you engage your friends, or even strangers, in conversation in real life. You greet them with a brief comment and a question. "What a beautiful day today. What are you going to do?" Or, "I love your sweater, where did you find it?" Perhaps, "Your dog is so sweet. Is she friendly?"

But, it's difficult to ask questions and start a dialog digitally, so if you actually want to engage people, you are going to have to do something different.

Keep it as simple as possible. Don't bury a question at the bottom of an email newsletter and expect people to answer it. You may get a few responses, but you will get far more engagement by sending a dedicated email, with a brief prompt, and just asking the question. The same is true on your website. Simple, clear, and prominent questions yield the best results.

What does it look like to ask questions rather than just broadcast information? Let's look at how we attempt to engage people around the renewal process. You are probably sending email after email telling people that their membership is expiring. You send them a:

90 day notice.

60 day notice.

30 day notice.

15 day notice.

Countless other notices once the grace period begins.

You send, maybe quite literally, a dozen reminders. And yet, you have tons of former members who let their membership lapse that you never heard from. You've trained them to ignore your emails.

One of the most popular Conversational Engagement campaigns our clients run attempts to win back lapsed members. It all starts with a simple question: “Did you know your membership lapsed?”

Remember, these are people who have probably received 12 emails by this point telling them their membership was going to expire, warning them that it will expire soon and finally telling them that they lapsed, so you would think they would know by now, right?

Almost every time we ask this question, more than 50 percent of respondents say, “No, I didn’t know my membership had lapsed.” Sometimes it’s as high as 80 percent, and rarely is it below 40 percent who didn’t know.

If you send people informational emails, the odds are they will do what they have been trained to do. The best case is, they glance at them and move on. But, if you send someone a question, they are more likely to do what they’ve been trained to do when someone asks them a question: they will answer.

And with an answer comes context. Without context you have no idea how to continue the conversation, so you just send them another email. With context, you know if they’re planning to renew and if they have or have not yet. You will know if they are not planning to renew, why not?

By taking this approach, you can direct the people who are willing and able to renew on their own through the process, and those who want or need your help are able to raise their hand to continue the conversation. Make sure you get in touch with them.

The most common conversations we see associations having with members fall into a few categories:

New Member Acquisition	Lapsed Members
New Member Onboarding	Dormant Member Win-Back
Net Promoter Score (NPS)	Membership Renewals
Certification	Quizzes
General Member Engagement	Miscellaneous
Profile Building	Conference Registration & Event Engagement

The following pages offer questions for each category of conversation, giving you plenty of options based on what type of engagement you are looking to achieve with your members.

New Member Acquisition

Member acquisition happens across both your website and email, and the strongest campaigns use both channels together. Instead of simply telling people about your association and hoping they take action, consider asking a few intentional questions. The answers give you insight into what individuals care about, what they need right now, and whether membership could be a good fit. Over time, these insights allow you to deliver more relevant information, connect member priorities to your offerings, and guide people toward the next step without guesswork. Here are a few questions to help you get started.

CASE STUDY

Want more on member acquisition? See how the Academy of Model Aeronautics engaged 1,400 nonmembers to convert them to members:

www.propfuel.com/case-studies/ama-website-engagement-membership-revenue

- ☐ What's most important to you this year?
- ☐ What's top of mind for you in your work right now?
- ☐ Which of these priorities is most important to you or your business?
- ☐ What industry issue keeps you up at night?
- ☐ What support would make the biggest impact for you right now?
- ☐ What would you like to do next?
- ☐ Are you interested in becoming a member?
- ☐ How can we help you achieve your goals?
- ☐ Would you like to explore membership options that align with your goals?
- ☐ Do you plan to join?
- ☐ Would you be interested in learning more about membership?
- ☐ Would you consider joining?
- ☐ Why have you hesitated to join?
- ☐ What's held you back from joining so far?
- ☐ What else could we offer to encourage you to join?
- ☐ Is there anything we can do to help you join?
- ☐ Are you interested in a free trial membership?
- ☐ Are you interested in joining now and saving 10%?
- ☐ Would you like a comparison of membership benefits?
- ☐ What would make membership feel like a clear next step for you?

New Member Onboarding

So, you have new members and want to get to know them. Instead of leading with a long list of benefits (which is really about the association), start by learning about the member. Asking a few intentional questions early helps you understand why they joined, what they need right now, and how they define value. Over time, this insight allows you to personalize onboarding, deliver more relevant information, and continually reinforce the value members receive from your association. Here are a few questions to help you get started.

CASE STUDY

Want more about member onboarding? Check out ASAE's campaign to connect with members on various aspects of their career, member experience and needs.

info.propfuel.com/asae-100qs

- ☐ Why did you join our association?
- ☐ Which benefit or resource are you most excited to explore first?
- ☐ How confident do you feel navigating your membership benefits today? What would help?
- ☐ How would you describe where you are in your career?
- ☐ Where would you like to be in your career in 5 years?
- ☐ What's the best way for us to communicate member information with you?
- ☐ Would you be interested in volunteer or committee opportunities? Why or why not? And what interests you?
- ☐ What's your #1 goal this year?
- ☐ What's most important to you as you manage your career in the year ahead?
- ☐ What are you hoping to get out of your membership this year?
- ☐ How do you prefer to connect with other members?
- ☐ How well have we met your expectations so far? What could we do better?
- ☐ What topic is top of mind right now?
- ☐ What type of support do you need at this stage of your career?
- ☐ Do you have any employment updates to share?
- ☐ How do you prefer to learn?
- ☐ How would you describe your professional peer group?
- ☐ Which of these challenges keeps you up at night?
- ☐ Would you like to get involved in our mentorship program?
- ☐ What does success look like for you in your first year as a member?
- ☐ Looking back on the last year, have your personal or business objectives changed?
- ☐ What resource have you found most valuable this year?

Net Promoter Score

Net Promoter Score (NPS) is a simple, widely used way to measure overall satisfaction, perceived value, and loyalty. It can be sent once, or periodically over time, to understand how members feel about their relationship with your association or a specific experience. If you're new to NPS, or unsure how to apply it beyond a single survey, the key is pairing the score with a thoughtful follow-up question. The score tells you what someone feels; the follow-up tells you why. Here are a few ways to use NPS to gauge the health of your member relationships.

- ☐ How likely would you be to recommend membership to a friend or colleague? What was the primary reason for your score?
- ☐ How likely would you be to recommend our event to a colleague in the industry? What could we do to improve the event?
- ☐ Given your experience with our association, how likely would you be to recommend membership to a colleague in the industry? What could we do better?
- ☐ Given your experience with our association to date, how likely would you be to refer us to an associate? How could we improve your experience?

Certification

Certifications and credentials are often some of the most valuable (and complex) programs an association offers. Whether your association administers the credential or supports one within your industry, there's a lot to communicate: eligibility, education requirements, continuing education, renewals, and deadlines. But sending information isn't the same as engaging the right people at the right time. Asking a few intentional questions can help you identify who's interested, who's active, who's at risk of lapsing, and who could benefit from additional support. Here are a few questions to help start those conversations.

- ☐ Are you currently pursuing a certification or credential?
- ☐ What motivated you to pursue (or consider) certification?
- ☐ What questions do you have about the certification process?
- ☐ Would you like to learn more about discounted/free CE?
- ☐ Would you like to renew your certification?
- ☐ Would you like to submit CE credits towards your certification?
- ☐ Have you found your certification to be valuable? Why or why not?
- ☐ Would you recommend getting certified to a colleague?
- ☐ In what ways has your certification helped you in your career?
- ☐ Do you hold other certifications?
- ☐ Did you know your certification has expired?
- ☐ Is there a reason you've let your certification lapse?
- ☐ Is there anything we can do to help with your certification journey?

General Member Engagement

You have your list of members; now, how do you stay meaningfully connected throughout the year? Instead of defaulting to one informational email after another, try asking a question periodically. Members want to be heard, not just informed. Even a single, well-timed question can uncover what matters most right now and help you engage in more relevant ways over time. Here are a few questions to help you keep the conversation going.

- ☐ What's your #1 goal this year?
- ☐ What's the best way for us to communicate member information with you? What other method might work for you?
- ☐ Would you be interested in volunteer or committee opportunities? Why or why not? And what interests you?
- ☐ What's most important to you as you manage your career in the year ahead?
- ☐ What are you hoping to get out of your membership this year?
- ☐ How do you prefer to connect with other members?
- ☐ How well have we met your expectations as a member of the association? What could we do better?
- ☐ What topic is top of mind right now?
- ☐ What type of support do you need at this stage of your career?
- ☐ Do you have any employment updates to share?
- ☐ How do you prefer to learn?
- ☐ How would you describe your professional peer group?
- ☐ Which of these challenges keeps you up at night?
- ☐ Would you like to get involved in our mentorship program?
- ☐ To what degree are we giving you what you need?
- ☐ Looking back on the last year, have your personal or business objectives changed?
- ☐ What resource have you found most valuable this year?
- ☐ Are you interested in becoming more involved as a member of our association?
- ☐ Why did you become a member of this association?

General Member Engagement, cont'd

- ☐ How clear are you on the benefits included with your membership? How could we communicate membership value more clearly?
- ☐ Is there a benefit you don't fully understand or haven't used yet?
- ☐ What would you change if you were on the board of our association?
- ☐ What do you value most as a member of our association? Tell us more.
- ☐ How well does our association support you with timely insights or thought leadership? (5 being very well) What could we do better?
- ☐ Do you get a good return on your investment as a member of our association? (5 being the best) What could we do better?
- ☐ Do you get reimbursed for your membership dues?
- ☐ How well does our association's advocacy work reflect your views and opinions? (5 being very well) Tell us more.
- ☐ How connected do you currently feel to peers in your industry? How can we help?
- ☐ Would you recommend membership in our association to a colleague? What could we do better?
- ☐ Do you know who to contact on our team if you need help?
- ☐ On what social media platform do you spend most of your time?
- ☐ How well do we provide you opportunities to network with fellow members of our industry? Do you have any ideas on how we can improve?
- ☐ Would you recommend membership in our association to a friend or colleague?

CASE STUDY

Want another idea for how to engage members? See how NYACP uses quizzes to add value and get members involved!

info.propfuel.com/nyacp-100qs

Profile Building

How do you encourage members to keep their profiles up to date? Asking members to log into your website or AMS often results in low participation. Logging in, finding the right page, and updating fields can be surprisingly friction-filled—and many members abandon the task before finishing. Instead, consider collecting profile data the same way you build engagement: by asking one simple question at a time. When asked periodically throughout the membership lifecycle, these questions feel easy to answer—and allow you to update member records for them. Here are a few profile-building questions to get you started.

CASE STUDY

Want more on profile building? Check out how PIHRA helped members update their profile information quickly and easily.

info.propfuel.com/pihra-100qs

- ☐ What's an alternative email address where we can reach you?
- ☐ What is your primary phone number?
- ☐ Would you like to change your (insert field) now?
- ☐ What is your top career priority this year?
- ☐ When do you plan on retiring?
- ☐ Which category best describes your current profession?
- ☐ How would you describe where you are in your career?
- ☐ When is your expected graduation date?
- ☐ What is your current job title?
- ☐ Is your mailing address correct?
- ☐ Who is your current employer?

Lapsed Members

So, you have a list of lapsed members who won't respond or rejoin your association? How frustrating! You might've already tried to send them multiple emails, enticing them with membership discounts and reminding them of your member benefits, and nothing works. Have you tried to ask them why? Are you sure they're aware of their lapsed status? Try asking them! You'll get valuable, new information and perhaps manage to re-engage them. Here are a few questions to try:

CASE STUDY

Want more on lapsed members? See what HSMAI did in an effort to win back over 700 lapsed members.

info.propfuel.com/hsmai-100qs

- ☐ Are you aware that your membership has lapsed?
- ☐ Are you considering rejoining our association as a member?
- ☐ We haven't heard from you. Are you planning to renew your membership?
- ☐ Are you planning to renew your membership?
- ☐ Did you know that your membership expired?
- ☐ Would you like to renew now?
- ☐ Why are you hesitating to renew your membership?
- ☐ Is there anything we can do to help you renew your membership?
- ☐ How would you like to reinstate your membership?
- ☐ What did you value most as a member of our association?
- ☐ What is most important to you or your business this year?
- ☐ What's your #1 priority this year?

Dormant Member Win-Back

Dormant members are past members who have not rejoined for an extended period of time. They're sleepy! How do you wake them up? Instead of reminding them – once again – that they're not a member, consider asking them some questions to get insights into why they haven't rejoined. It will give you valuable information on what to do next. Here are some ideas for what to ask:

- ☐ What was your primary reason for leaving the association?
- ☐ What can we do to get you to renew with our association?
- ☐ Would a discounted membership bring you back as a member?
- ☐ What dollar amount is membership worth to you?
- ☐ Would you like to rejoin?
- ☐ Would rejoining [Association] be of value/be of interest to you?
- ☐ Did you join a different professional association?
- ☐ What can we do to get you to renew with our association?
- ☐ Do you expect to rejoin the association later in your career?
- ☐ What can we do to get you to renew with our association now?
- ☐ Why did you originally join our association?
- ☐ How have we fallen below your expectations?
- ☐ If you were on the leadership team of the association, what would you change?
- ☐ Are you considering rejoining our association as a member? Why or why not?
- ☐ What should we start, stop, continue doing to add value for you?
- ☐ Would you be willing to have one of our staff visit with you?
- ☐ What's the best way to reach you?
- ☐ Is there anything we can do to help you rejoin?
- ☐ Why are you hesitating to rejoin?
- ☐ How would you like to reinstate your membership?

Membership Renewals

It's renewal time... what's your solution to get more members to renew? If it involves sending another email to tell them to rejoin, perhaps try something different. Instead of telling them about their impending member expiration, consider asking them a question about their membership. You'll gain new information about individual members, figure out how to help them and maybe even get them to act. Here are some ideas to get you started:

- ☐ Are you planning on renewing your membership? Why or why not?
- ☐ What do you most value as a member of our association? Is there anything else?
- ☐ Did you know your membership is expiring?
- ☐ Why are you hesitating to renew your membership?
- ☐ Are you ready to renew now?
- ☐ Would you like to renew your membership now?
- ☐ Is there anything we can do to help you renew?
- ☐ What member benefit has been the most valuable to you this past year?
- ☐ Are you aware that your membership has lapsed?
- ☐ What can we do to get you to renew with our association?
- ☐ How valuable has your membership been this year?

Quizzes

If your members hold an industry certification or credential, they need to keep up with their education! While webinars, online session libraries and study courses are useful, they require a time commitment. Try something new: an email quiz! It commands only a few minutes from your members, mixes up the typical communications coming from your organization, and offers immediate member value. Here are some steps to take to create a quiz:

- 1 Source educational content from internal or external sources (exams, study guides, prep courses).
- 2 Create questions from the content which will stretch your members' understanding of concepts.
- 3 Use your email platform to create a question/answer style email template, and create a regular schedule for sending out quiz questions.
- 4 Share the answer either on a landing page or in the following week's quiz email.

As an alternative, you can take a question that came in from an individual member – an industry or business question – and ask your entire membership for their input. Members love to talk and share!

Miscellaneous

Are you looking to mix it up a little with your members? The same association-focused emails can get dull over time and cause your members to check out mentally from your organization. Keep it interesting by asking them some out-of-the box questions! Here are some ideas:

- ☐ How has your (association) membership made you a better (insert title)?
- ☐ Will you commit to a donation?
- ☐ Which of these issues is keeping you up at night?
- ☐ How well does our association's advocacy work reflect your views and opinions?
- ☐ Describe a typical day of work for you.
- ☐ Describe your dream vacation.
- ☐ How are you feeling about your job this week?
- ☐ How could we help you grow in your current role?
- ☐ What would you like to see us do differently?
- ☐ If you could live anywhere in the world for a time, where would it be and why?
- ☐ If you had one extra hour of free time a day, how would you use it?
- ☐ Name three things you think will become obsolete in ten years.
- ☐ What are the bottlenecks in your business and how could we eliminate them?
- ☐ What are your most recent big win(s)?
- ☐ What is making your job harder than it needs to be?
- ☐ What is one new thing you would like to learn how to do this year at work?
- ☐ What is one new thing you would like to learn how to do this year outside of work?
- ☐ What is your biggest challenge and how can we help?
- ☐ What project from the past year are you most proud of?
- ☐ What's one thing you learned last week?
- ☐ What's one big goal you would like to accomplish in your life?
- ☐ DEI questions related to your association's mission or industry.

Conference Registration & Event Engagement

How are you encouraging your members to attend events and engage before, during and after the event? Incessant calls to action, along with bulletin board-style emails with a load of information, can overwhelm members and attendees and cause them to stop paying attention. Instead of telling them more information, consider asking them questions one at a time, periodically throughout the conference registration and onsite timeframes, to capture the Voice of the Member. Here are some ideas for what to ask:

- ☐ Are you planning to register for (event/conference)?
- ☐ What is holding you back from registering?
- ☐ Is now a better time to register for (event/conference)?
- ☐ In which of these (conference/event) topics are you most interested?
- ☐ What did you learn at the conference that you're currently applying to your day-to-day activities? Anything else?
- ☐ How would you rate the overall experience at {event/conference}? (5 being the best)
- ☐ How would you rate the food at {event/conference}? (5 being the best)
- ☐ How would you rate the venue at {event/conference}? (5 being the best)
- ☐ How would you rate the speaker at {event/conference}? (5 being the best)
- ☐ What's the best way for us to communicate event/conference information with you?

Follow up

Your most important contribution to Conversational Engagement is follow up. The concept is simple: a conversation requires two people to participate, so if you don't follow up, the conversation is over. Of course, this is easy to do in person, or when carrying on a few conversations with a few people over a few days. But how do you keep a conversation going with hundreds of people at the same time? You need systems and automation to give you conversational superpowers.

Automation gives you a few advantages. The first advantage is that a lot of conversations can happen without you even knowing about it. How does that work? Well, remember that a conversation is a back and forth exchange of information. This is something you can do entirely with technology, taking advantage of workflows that analyze what people tell you, and take action to deliver additional content, more questions, or whatever process you design.

Using workflows and automation, you can have a conversational interaction with 90 percent of people who interact with you without ever needing personal intervention. Of course, not all requests fall neatly into a bucket that can be handled via automation, and that is where systems come into play.

A good Conversational Engagement system will surface those instances where you do need to get involved and give you tools to easily handle the flow of those conversations as they progress. An easy way to do that in PropFuel is to tag people who respond to a question with an answer that requires follow up.

For example, let's look at renewals again. If someone says "Yes, I'm planning to renew," tag them for follow up. You can then build a list a few days later that contains the people who said they were planning to renew, and using the data from your AMS through an integration, filter out those who did actually renew. Now you have a list of people who have shown intent to renew but haven't done it yet: a perfect opportunity to follow up manually via email or phone call to complete the renewal.

Another example where categorizing people for follow up is useful is with Net Promoter Score (NPS). In this case, you are asking people to rate how likely they are to recommend your organization to a colleague of theirs. This tactic gives you a net score that you can use to benchmark your organization, but it also allows you to slot the respondents into three categories.

You have your promoters, those are the ones who think you are doing great. You can reach out to them and ask for referrals and reviews.

Then you have the passives and detractors; those people often leave a comment telling you why they didn't rate you higher. You can go a long way toward improving their opinion of you by reaching out to them and addressing their issues. Conversation solves a lot of problems and changes sentiment dramatically.

“How likely are you to recommend us to a colleague or friend?”

Another example of how systems can help you better follow up with people is with response templates. Quite often, you will have a group of say 20 members who are asking for the same or similar thing. Response templates allow you to craft a personalized response and use it as a starting point for each email you send, allowing you to include small tweaks to each personal response that you send, without having to start from scratch each time. Templates also allow you to choose who you are sending from; so for example, staff can send personal responses from the Director of Membership without the Director having to do all the work from their inbox.

The good news is that the way your organization chooses to follow up can be catered to the human and technological resources you have available. For example, if your staff is maxed out on time and won't have enough time to follow up via phone or email on open text replies in a campaign, no problem. There are other options, like adding those who respond with open text to another campaign that asks additional questions, which can narrow down the number of individuals who need one-on-one assistance. The possibilities for follow up are unlimited and can be as unique as an individual, in person response would be.

Getting started

Systems like PropFuel can help you implement a Conversational Engagement strategy across your organization, but you don't need a system to take the Ask – Capture – Act methodology and try it out in some of your communications. Next time you send an email, think about how you can make that communication a little more conversational.

It may be as simple as adding a quiz question at the bottom and asking them to reply with the answer. It could be simply emailing 100 random members and asking them how you can help. Start small and work your way up.

The one thing you will find, no matter the scale at which you are operating, is that your members will be grateful for the attention. They will get more value and feel more connected to your organization because you gave them an opportunity to speak up rather than only consuming what your organization is communicating.

"I was pulling some data now that we are one year into our use of PropFuel for our renewal campaigns and was pretty shocked by the shifts we have seen... the new campaign has really moved the needle on when our members are renewing – which is a great reduction of resource usage on our staff time and paper bill mailing, phone calls, etc."

Amanda, Chief Strategy Officer, AAMFT

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